# How Marketing Companies Are Marketing in the AI Era

Marketing in the AI era is shifting from a campaign-centered model to an **always-on decision system**. Marketing companies are using AI to understand demand, generate and adapt creative, buy media, personalize experiences, operate customer conversations, and measure outcomes. The important change is not that marketers can produce more copy or images. It is that AI is moving influence earlier in the customer journey, especially into search, recommendation, comparison, and purchase decisions.

The practical result is a new competitive equation:

> **Advantage = trusted brand data + distinctive human ideas + machine-scale execution + measurable business lift.**

Companies that treat AI only as a content shortcut usually produce more noise. Companies that connect AI to customer data, distribution, experimentation, and governance can change the economics and speed of marketing.

## 1. The market has moved from experimentation toward operating-model change

AI use is now widespread, but enterprise value is still uneven. McKinsey's 2026 global survey found that nearly nine in ten respondents reported regular AI use in at least one business function, while 44% said AI was scaling across the enterprise. At the same time, only 37% attributed any EBIT impact to AI, and the share of high-performing organizations reporting significant financial impact remained about 6%. [1]

That gap explains the current behavior of serious marketing organizations. They are moving from isolated experiments—"give everyone a chatbot" or "generate some social posts"—toward a smaller number of connected, high-value workflows. The goal is not tool adoption. The goal is to redesign how marketing work gets done.

The shift is visible in the move toward **agentic AI**. An ordinary generative tool produces an answer when prompted. An agentic system can plan and execute a series of actions across systems, such as identifying a customer segment, drafting an offer, checking brand rules, requesting approval, launching a campaign, monitoring results, and recommending the next test. McKinsey reports that 40% of respondents at organizations with more than $1 billion in revenue said they were scaling AI agents in at least one function, up from 27% the prior year. [1]

Marketing and sales are among the functions where this matters most because the work is already composed of repeatable decisions: who to target, what to say, which channel to

use, how much to bid, when to follow up, and whether an interaction should be escalated to a person.

Adobe’ s 2026 Digital Trends research shows the same pattern from the customer-experience side. Organizations report improvements in personalization, lead generation, and retention from early generative-AI work, but integration across multiple functions remains limited. Fifty-two percent say they struggle to demonstrate measurable returns from AI using customer-experience metrics, while 56% say leadership emphasizes purely financial outcomes when evaluating AI initiatives. 2

The implication is straightforward: the winning marketing companies are building **systems**, not collecting disconnected AI features.

# 2. What marketing companies are actually doing with AI

## 2.1 Research and insight generation

AI is compressing the time required to turn messy information into an initial point of view. Marketing teams use models to summarize interviews, classify customer feedback, cluster reviews, identify recurring objections, compare competitors, generate hypotheses, and simulate how different audiences might interpret a message.

The best use is not asking a model for a generic market report. It is giving the system access to a carefully selected evidence base—reviews, call transcripts, CRM data, support tickets, search queries, social conversations, sales notes, and research documents—and asking it to identify patterns that a team can then validate.

This changes the role of research. Instead of conducting a large study only a few times a year, companies can maintain a continuously refreshed “voice of customer” layer. A brand might use it to detect that customers are not objecting to price itself but to uncertainty about installation, maintenance, or switching costs. That insight can change the offer and the creative more effectively than another round of surface-level demographic targeting.

The human work remains essential. AI can identify patterns and generate interpretations, but it cannot independently establish that a pattern is causal, representative, legal to use, or strategically important. Mature teams treat AI outputs as **hypotheses with provenance**, not as facts.

## 2.2 Segmentation and predictive targeting

Traditional segmentation assigns people to groups using relatively stable attributes. AI enables more dynamic segmentation based on intent, context, predicted need, likely value, behavior, and stage in the decision journey.

Examples include:

- grouping shoppers by the problem they are trying to solve rather than by age;
- identifying customers who are likely to churn before they show an obvious cancellation signal;
- predicting which offer will increase long-term value rather than merely produce a click;
- finding high-potential audiences that resemble profitable customers without relying on sensitive individual-level profiling;
- adapting a message to a person’ s stage, such as education, comparison, trial, purchase, or renewal.

Bain reports that retailers experimenting with AI-powered targeted campaigns have seen 10% to 25% higher returns on ad spend, while hyper-personalized campaigns have produced click-through-rate improvements of up to 40% in the examples it reviewed. [3] These are reported results, not universal benchmarks, and they depend heavily on data quality, offer quality, creative quality, and test design.

The most sophisticated marketers are also moving from “audience targeting” toward **decision targeting**. They ask which decision they want to influence—trial, upgrade, repeat purchase, consideration, or retention—and then let AI help select the next best action.

## 2.3 Creative development and content supply chains

AI is being used across the whole creative supply chain:

1. brief development and audience interpretation;
2. concept exploration and moodboarding;
3. copy and script drafts;
4. image, video, audio, and animation variation;
5. translation and localization;
6. resizing and channel adaptation;
7. product-feed enrichment and metadata generation;
8. brand and compliance checks;
9. test-cell construction;
10. performance-based iteration.

This is where the most visible productivity gains have appeared. Bain reports that campaign time to market has been reduced by up to 50% in leading examples and content creation time has fallen by 30% to 50%. [3] WPP reports that an integrated team using its

WPP Open platform produced more than 200 assets per sprint for one challenger brand, with an average 48% efficiency gain across more than 20 pilots. [4]

These examples illustrate an important distinction: AI is not just replacing one writer or designer. It is turning a single approved idea into a larger number of channel-ready, audience-specific, language-specific, and format-specific variants.

That enables a different creative strategy. The brand can maintain a small number of strong, distinctive ideas while testing many executions around them. The risk is that organizations optimize for asset volume instead of audience response. More variants do not automatically mean better marketing.

## 2.4 Personalization at scale

Personalization is moving beyond “Dear Jamie” and product recommendations. AI can tailor the sequence, emphasis, proof, imagery, offer, and call to action based on a customer’s needs and context.

Adobe’s research found that 80% of organizations expect future customer experiences to be highly personalized and anticipatory of customer needs in real time. [2] That expectation covers email, websites, commerce, support, retail, and post-purchase experiences.

In practice, companies are using AI to:

- select which content or product to show first;
- generate individualized email or SMS variations;
- determine when to send a message;
- recommend bundles or next steps;
- personalize landing pages and onboarding flows;
- adapt support responses to customer history;
- identify when a customer should be routed to a human;
- coordinate messages across paid, owned, and service channels.

The strongest programs personalize **meaningfully**. They use data to make the experience more useful, not merely more familiar. A customer should understand why the recommendation fits their stated problem. Otherwise personalization can feel like surveillance or manipulation.

## 2.5 Media planning, buying, and optimization

Advertising platforms are absorbing more of the planning and execution process. Google’s 2025 Ads releases included AI Max for Search, Smart Bidding Exploration,

expanded AI-powered campaign capabilities, advertising within AI Overviews, and testing of ads in AI Mode. [5]

The platform logic is changing from the marketer manually selecting every keyword, placement, audience, and bid toward the marketer providing business goals, creative assets, conversion signals, exclusions, and constraints. The platform then searches a larger decision space than a human team could manage.

This has two consequences.

First, the marketer’ s leverage shifts toward **inputs and controls**: product feeds, conversion definitions, first-party data, creative quality, negative keywords, brand-safety rules, audience exclusions, and value-based bidding signals.

Second, platform dependence increases. When the platform controls targeting and optimization, marketers need better independent measurement and stronger governance. Otherwise they may accept a platform’ s reported performance without knowing whether the results were incremental or merely captured demand that would have happened anyway.

IAB describes AI as affecting the full media lifecycle, including planning, audience segmentation, activation, real-time optimization, and performance measurement. [6] Agencies are responding by turning media teams into operators of systems rather than manual traders of individual placements.

## 2.6 Customer conversations and service-led marketing

Marketing is increasingly meeting customers inside conversations. Adobe found that one in four customers in its research already use AI-powered platforms as a primary source for information, recommendations, or purchase decisions, ahead of brand websites and online reviews. [2]

This creates two connected opportunities:

- brands can make their products and evidence easier for AI systems to understand and recommend;
- brands can offer their own conversational experiences for discovery, comparison, support, and purchase.

Conversational marketing works best when the system has access to accurate product facts, inventory, pricing, policies, customer history, and escalation routes. A chatbot that sounds fluent but cannot answer basic operational questions damages trust.

Adobe also found that a third of customers would disengage after learning content was AI-generated, and 37% would disengage if they discovered they were interacting with AI when

they expected a person. The preferred safeguard was the ability to switch to a human at any time. [2]

The lesson is not that companies must hide AI. It is that AI must be introduced in a way that preserves control, honesty, and a clear human path.

# 3. The biggest strategic change: discovery is moving into AI answers

Search marketing used to focus on winning a click from a results page. AI search increasingly tries to answer the question directly, summarize options, compare products, and recommend a next action.

McKinsey's 2025 AI Discovery Survey found that half of consumers surveyed intentionally use AI-powered search, and 44% of AI-search users said it was their primary and preferred source of insight, ahead of traditional search at 31%. [7] McKinsey projects that $750 billion in US consumer spending could flow through AI-powered search by 2028, while 20% to 50% of traditional-search traffic may be at risk as AI captures decisions earlier in the journey. [7]

These figures are projections and should not be treated as a guaranteed market outcome. The important strategic signal is the direction of travel: consumers are asking an AI system to synthesize information instead of visiting many separate websites.

## 3.1 SEO is becoming a broader visibility discipline

Search engine optimization still matters, but it is no longer sufficient. Brands now need to influence the information environment that AI systems use to formulate answers.

McKinsey found that a brand's own sites often make up only 5% to 10% of the sources referenced by AI-powered search. The rest may come from publishers, affiliate sites, reviews, forums, retailers, communities, and other third-party sources. [7]

That means modern search visibility has at least four layers:

- **technical discoverability:** the site can be crawled, understood, and retrieved;
- **entity clarity:** the brand, products, claims, prices, policies, and relationships are stated consistently;
- **independent corroboration:** trusted third parties, reviewers, communities, and publishers discuss the brand accurately;
- **answer-level visibility:** the brand appears in the actual AI answers for important questions, with favorable and accurate descriptions.

The emerging discipline is often called **generative engine optimization**, or GEO. The useful version of GEO is not a bag of tricks for forcing a model to mention a brand. It is a program

for making the brand genuinely easy to understand, verify, compare, and recommend.

### 3.2 What brands are doing in AI search

Companies are beginning to:

- monitor how AI systems describe their brand and competitors;
- test important prompts across multiple engines, regions, and customer segments;
- map which third-party sources are cited in answers;
- improve product data, structured content, and factual consistency;
- publish original evidence, comparisons, specifications, and expert guidance;
- strengthen review, creator, community, affiliate, and publisher relationships;
- correct inaccurate information at the source rather than only on their own site;
- track AI visibility, citation share, sentiment, recommendation position, and downstream action.

McKinsey reports that only 16% of brands in its CMO sample systematically track AI-search performance.[7] This creates an early-mover opportunity, but it also creates measurement risk because AI answers vary by model, location, query wording, date, and source set.

## 4. How agencies and marketing firms are changing their business models

The agency model is changing in three ways: the work is being industrialized, the service mix is expanding, and the relationship with the client is becoming more integrated.

### 4.1 From labor-based production to platform-enabled production

Historically, agencies sold combinations of strategic thinking, creative labor, media expertise, production capacity, and account management. AI reduces the marginal cost of many production tasks. This places pressure on pricing models based mainly on hours, headcount, or asset counts.

Agencies are responding by building proprietary platforms, shared data layers, workflow systems, prompt libraries, evaluation tools, and brand knowledge bases. These systems help them deliver more work with smaller or differently composed teams.

RSM’s review of 2025 earnings calls found that major marketing and advertising firms were emphasizing AI-driven media buying, predictive insights, faster creative production, centralized platforms, and technology-enabled client solutions. Dentsu said it planned to invest more than $250 million across AI and related initiatives.[8]

The strategic value of an agency is therefore moving away from “we can make more assets” toward “we can connect customer insight, creative, media, commerce, measurement, and governance into a repeatable growth system.”

## 4.2 From specialist handoffs to integrated teams

The old workflow often looked like this: strategy brief, creative brief, media plan, production, trafficking, reporting, and a series of approvals. AI makes the handoffs faster, but it also exposes their limitations. If the team is organized into silos, each silo can optimize its own output while the overall customer experience becomes inconsistent.

Newer operating models assemble multidisciplinary teams around an outcome or audience. A team may include a strategist, creative director, designer, data scientist, media operator, commerce specialist, marketing technologist, and AI workflow lead. They work from a shared set of customer signals and business goals.

WPP explicitly argues that simply adding AI to old ways of working will not deliver major gains. It recommends integrated teams spanning creative, media, and commerce, with the agency and client co-creating in a common environment. 4

## 4.3 From campaign delivery to continuous optimization

Campaigns have a start and end date. AI-enabled marketing systems are increasingly managed as continuous loops:

1. detect a demand signal or customer problem;
2. form a hypothesis;
3. create or select an intervention;
4. launch within agreed constraints;
5. observe behavior and business results;
6. test alternatives;
7. update the next action.

This creates new agency services: AI-search monitoring, content intelligence, experimentation, creative analytics, customer decisioning, marketing data engineering, AI governance, agent design, and operational transformation.

The agency may become less like a production vendor and more like a **growth operating partner**. That shift brings higher strategic value, but it also demands stronger accountability for business outcomes.

## 4.4 New pricing and commercial pressure

AI creates a tension. Clients want more speed, more variants, and lower costs. Agencies want to be paid for the strategy, systems, proprietary knowledge, and business impact that remain valuable even when production becomes cheaper.

Likely commercial models include:

- fixed fees for strategic design and implementation;
- platform or managed-service fees for AI-enabled workflows;
- retainers for continuous optimization and monitoring;
- performance-linked compensation for measurable incremental outcomes;
- shared-savings arrangements for production efficiency;
- licensing of proprietary data, tools, or workflow systems.

Pure performance pricing is difficult because marketing outcomes depend on price, distribution, inventory, product quality, sales execution, and macroeconomic conditions. The more practical model is usually a hybrid: guaranteed service scope plus bonuses tied to agreed, independently measured outcomes.

# 5. What the new marketing technology stack looks like

A modern AI marketing stack is less about one “AI platform” and more about the connections between layers.

## Data and identity

This layer includes customer data platforms, CRM, commerce data, consent records, product catalogs, event streams, support history, and clean-room or privacy-preserving collaboration environments. AI performance is constrained by missing, stale, duplicated, or poorly governed data.

## Intelligence and decisioning

This layer includes predictive models, recommendation systems, customer-value models, propensity models, segmentation, next-best-action logic, and large language models used for reasoning over approved evidence.

## Content and creative operations

This layer stores brand guidelines, product facts, approved claims, templates, visual assets, rights information, and evaluation rules. It supports generation, adaptation, translation, versioning, approval, and distribution.

### Activation

This includes advertising platforms, email, SMS, websites, apps, commerce systems, retail media, customer-service tools, social platforms, and sales enablement. AI increasingly acts through these systems rather than merely advising a human.

### Measurement and experimentation

This includes conversion tracking, incrementality tests, marketing mix modeling, customer lifetime value, cohort analysis, brand lift, attention, and quality metrics. AI can speed analysis, but it cannot eliminate the need for a credible counterfactual.

### Governance and observability

This layer records which model was used, what data it accessed, what it generated, who approved it, what constraints applied, and what happened after launch. It also monitors hallucinations, bias, off-brand language, privacy violations, copyright issues, and abnormal behavior.

The core architectural principle is **separation of generation from authorization**. A model can propose a campaign, but a policy engine and accountable person should determine whether it may be published, to whom, in which market, and under which claims.

## 6. Measurement is being rebuilt around incrementality and business outcomes

AI increases the number of decisions and variations in marketing. That makes weak measurement more dangerous, not less.

Platform dashboards often report attributed conversions. Attribution can be useful for optimization within a platform, but it does not necessarily tell a company whether the ad caused an incremental sale. AI systems can become extremely good at finding people who were already likely to convert, producing attractive reported efficiency without producing equivalent new demand.

Serious marketing organizations are therefore combining several forms of evidence:

- **platform attribution** for fast tactical optimization;
- **holdout and lift tests** to estimate causal impact;
- **media mix modeling** for aggregate budget allocation across online and offline channels;
- **customer cohort and lifetime-value analysis** to distinguish immediate revenue from durable value;

- **brand and consideration measures** for effects that appear before purchase;
- **AI visibility measures** such as citation share and recommendation presence;
- **operational measures** such as time to market, cost per approved asset, and human review burden.

The measurement question is evolving from “which ad got credit?” to “what would have happened without this intervention, and what is the value of the change?”

Google’s 2025 Ads updates show this direction. The company highlighted Meridian, an open-source media mix modeling solution, and introduced richer asset-level reporting and new-customer acquisition cost reporting alongside additional automation.[5]

Bain’s advice is similar: set measurable operational, customer, or financial targets, then concentrate on a small number of high-impact use cases instead of scattering effort across many pilots.[3]

# 7. Why AI-generated marketing often fails

The failure modes are predictable.

## Generic sameness

When many companies use the same models and prompts, their output converges. The content may be grammatically correct and visually polished but strategically interchangeable. Distinctiveness must come from proprietary customer knowledge, a real point of view, original evidence, cultural understanding, and strong creative direction.

## Scale without strategy

AI can create ten thousand variants before a team has decided which customer problem it is solving. This produces an efficient content factory with no useful editorial judgment.

## Hallucinated claims

A model can invent statistics, product features, testimonials, sources, or compliance language. In marketing, a fluent falsehood is not a harmless error. It can become a regulatory, legal, or reputational problem.

## Personalization that feels invasive

The fact that a company can infer something does not mean it should say it. Personalization should be judged by customer benefit, expectation, consent, and sensitivity—not only by predicted conversion rate.

### Platform opacity

Automated media systems can make decisions that are difficult for marketers to inspect. The organization may know that performance changed without knowing which audiences, placements, or generated assets caused the change.

### Workforce dislocation without redesign

If leaders use AI only to reduce headcount, they may remove the people needed for judgment, brand stewardship, research quality, and client trust. The better model uses automation to reduce repetitive work while increasing the proportion of time spent on strategy, creativity, experimentation, and relationship building.

## 8. Responsible AI is now a marketing capability, not just a legal review

The risk is already material. An IAB survey of 125 US advertising-industry executives found that 70% had experienced at least one AI-related incident, including hallucinations, biased or inappropriate content, off-brand or offensive material, creative-control problems, and compliance failures. Forty percent said they had to pause or pull ads, and more than a third dealt with brand damage or public-relations issues. [9]

The same survey found that only about one-third of brands, agencies, and publishers had adopted or planned to adopt formal governance tools, and only 6% believed current safeguards were enough. [9]

A practical governance program should include:

- an inventory of approved models, tools, and data sources;
- risk tiers for different use cases;
- a library of approved claims and evidence;
- rights and provenance records for images, music, voices, and likenesses;
- human review requirements based on risk, not just content type;
- automated testing for factuality, bias, unsafe content, privacy, and brand alignment;
- red-team testing for prompt injection and adversarial inputs;
- disclosure rules for synthetic or AI-mediated experiences;
- incident logging and rollback procedures;
- clear ownership across marketing, legal, security, data, procurement, and agency partners.

The legal baseline remains conventional even when the production method is novel. The FTC states that advertising claims must be truthful, not deceptive or unfair, and evidence-based.[10] Using AI does not transfer responsibility to the model provider.

The US Copyright Office is continuing to analyze digital replicas, copyrightability of AI-generated outputs, and training data. Its Part 2 report addresses the copyrightability of outputs created using generative AI.[11] Marketing teams should therefore preserve records of human contribution, source material, licenses, and approvals, especially for high-value campaigns.

In the EU, the AI Act's transparency rules took effect in August 2026. The European Commission says providers of generative AI must ensure AI-generated content is identifiable, while certain AI-generated content such as deepfakes must be clearly labeled. Organizations also need to inform people when they are interacting with a machine where that information is relevant to trust and informed choice.[12]

Regulation will vary by market, but the operational answer is global traceability and clear customer control.

# 9. The emerging competitive playbook

The companies most likely to win are not necessarily the ones with the biggest AI budgets. They are the ones that connect a few capabilities well.

## Build a distinctive knowledge base

Give AI access to verified product data, customer language, approved claims, research, policies, and brand principles. A model grounded in generic web text will produce generic marketing.

## Choose a small number of high-value workflows

Start with problems such as reducing campaign cycle time, improving renewal, increasing qualified demand, accelerating localization, or improving product discovery. Define a baseline and a target before building the system.

## Design the whole workflow

Do not automate only the writing step. Redesign briefing, data access, generation, review, approval, launch, monitoring, and learning as one process.

## Use AI to expand testing, not dilute the idea

Maintain a strong creative platform. Use AI to test executions, formats, audiences, offers,

and sequences around that platform.

### Invest in AI-era discovery

Track how customers ask questions in AI systems. Improve the sources that those systems rely on. Publish information that is useful, specific, original, and verifiable. Monitor brand visibility and sentiment across multiple answer engines.

### Measure causal and durable value

Use platform data for operations, but use experiments, mix models, cohorts, and business metrics to make investment decisions.

### Put humans at the points of consequence

Keep accountable human ownership for claims, sensitive targeting, public-facing brand expression, high-stakes decisions, and irreversible actions. Automate the routine; supervise the consequential.

## 10. What changes for marketing roles

AI will not eliminate every marketing role, but it will change what distinguishes strong practitioners.

Strategists will spend less time assembling summaries and more time framing the problem, choosing tradeoffs, and identifying the insight that should guide action.

Creatives will spend less time producing every adaptation manually and more time developing distinctive ideas, directing systems, judging quality, and protecting cultural relevance.

Media specialists will spend less time adjusting individual bids and more time designing goals, signals, constraints, experiments, and cross-platform measurement.

Data and marketing-technology specialists will become more important because AI needs clean data, reliable integrations, evaluation systems, and permissioned access.

Account leaders will need to coordinate a more technical service model and explain AI decisions in business language. Clients will expect agencies to understand both brand and operating economics.

New roles will grow around AI workflow design, prompt and knowledge management, model evaluation, content provenance, AI-search intelligence, synthetic-content production, and marketing governance.

The common thread is that the valuable marketer becomes a **designer and judge of systems**, not merely a producer of individual outputs.

## 11. A realistic 12–24 month outlook

The near-term future is likely to be less dramatic than fully autonomous marketing, but more consequential than simple content automation.

In the next phase, companies will continue to automate creative adaptation, research synthesis, media optimization, customer-service responses, and campaign operations. AI search will become a regular part of brand visibility reporting. Agencies will consolidate tools into fewer platforms and will compete on proprietary data, workflow integration, talent, and proof of business impact.

Agentic systems will expand, but high-value customer-facing actions will remain constrained by permissions, brand risk, data quality, and the need for human escalation. Adobe’s research shows why: organizations are ambitious about agentic AI, while customers remain sensitive to undisclosed automation and want human control. 2

The main bottleneck will shift from model capability to organizational capability. Companies will struggle with fragmented data, unclear ownership, weak measurement, inconsistent brand rules, and teams that have not been trained to work in new ways.

That is why the AI-era marketing leader should ask five questions:

1. **Where is the customer decision moving?** Search, social, retail media, communities, conversational interfaces, or agents?
2. **What proprietary knowledge do we have that generic models do not?**
3. **Which workflow can produce measurable value if redesigned end to end?**
4. **What evidence would prove that AI caused better business performance?**
5. **Where must a human remain accountable?**

The durable lesson is simple. Marketing companies are not winning by generating the most content. They are winning by making better decisions faster, distributing them across more relevant contexts, learning from real outcomes, and preserving trust while they scale.

## References


[1] The State of AI: Global Survey 2026

[2] Adobe 2026 AI and Digital Trends report

[3] Generative AI in Marketing: Five Steps to Scale for Real ROI

[4] To unlock AI's value look to your operating model

[5] Google Ads Highlights of 2025

[6] State of Data 2025: The Now, The Near, and The Next Evolution of AI for Media Campaigns

[7] New front door to the internet: Winning in the age of AI search

[8] Marketing and advertising firms double down on AI, client engagement, talent in Q2
[9] AI Adoption Is Surging in Advertising, but Is the Industry Prepared for Responsible AI?
[10] Advertising and Marketing
[11] Copyright and Artificial Intelligence
[12] AI Act: Regulatory framework for artificial intelligence